

L2A™

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(b) Define structuralism. What are its main aspects and how does it differ from structural Functionalism

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Structuralism is an anthropological theory given by Levi Strauss in his work 'The Elementary structure of Kinship (1949)' & by Edmund Leach in his 'Political systems of Highland Burma (1951)'

Key Concepts

- 1) Levi Strauss defined structuralism as 'the underlying pattern of human thought in all human activities.'
- 2) He argued that models making up social structure are devised in mind through human thought process.
- 3) Levi Strauss wanted to establish facts true about human mind & universalize it.

- 4) Edmund Leach on the other hand wanted to do ~~the~~ 'structural analysis' on particular society ~~and~~ unlike Strauss.

Methodology

- 1) They used 'structural analysis' taking inspiration from Noam Chomsky 'structural linguistics'
- 2) Both used binary opposition to explain process?
- 3) Levi Strauss used it on 'studying kinship system' while Leach used it to do structural analysis of 'Biblical Myth'

Criticism

→ Malvin Harris structuralism is too abstract to apply elsewhere

→ Levi Strauss was criticised for universalizing human thought process as there are various variations across societies.

Difference from structural functionalism

- Structural functionalism was given by Radcliffe Brown in his work on The Andaman Islanders (1910)

Structuralism

- 1) It is the underlying pattern of human thought in all activities.
- 2) Focused more on human thought process
- 3) Inspired by structural linguistics & Marcel Mauss
- 4) Given by Levi Strauss & Edmund Leach

Structural - functionalism

- 1) Various institutions in society functions in order to maintain social structure
- 2) Focused more on society
- 3) Inspired by Durkheim
- 4) Given by Radcliffe Brown

Hence, structuralism added a new perspective to anthropology in 20th century.

